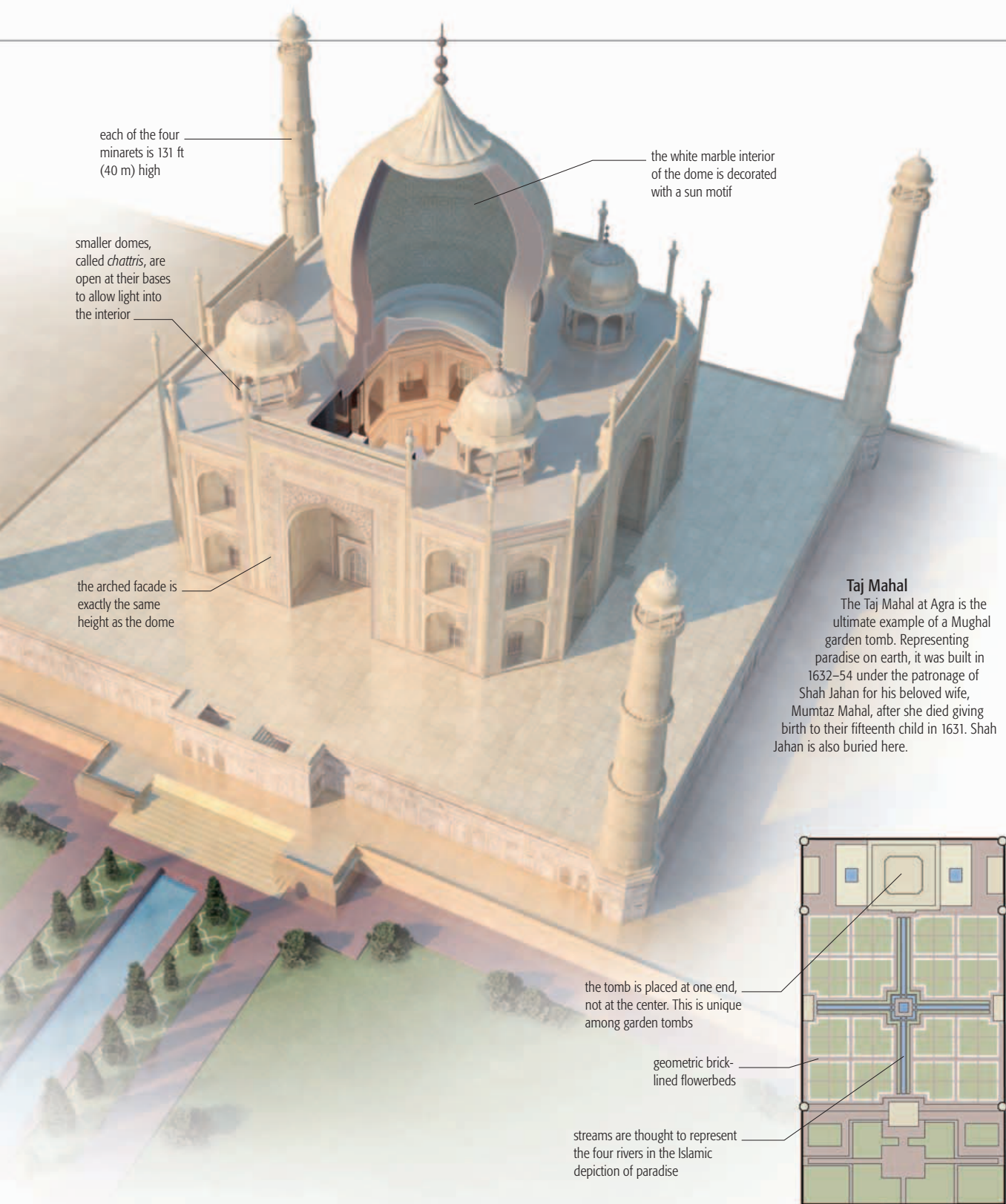




Taj Mahal

The Taj Mahal at Agra is the ultimate example of a Mughal garden tomb. Representing paradise on earth, it was built in 1632–54 under the patronage of Shah Jahan for his beloved wife, Mumtaz Mahal, after she died giving birth to their fifteenth child in 1631. Shah Jahan is also buried here.

political move that would help to unite the many faiths of his empire. He also allowed the Hindu Rajputs to negotiate entry into his nobility if they offered their daughters in marriage. Eventually, he relied more on Rajputs and Persians than on his own Central Asian nobles.

Reform and the arts

During his reign, Akbar also reduced the influence of Muslim scholars (*‘ulama*), abolished taxes on Hindu pilgrims and non-Muslim residents (*jizya*), and introduced the Bengali calendar, a solar calendar to replace the Muslim lunar cycle. At his new palace at Fatehpur Sikri near Agra, he held

religious debates in a custom-built *ibadat-khana*, or “house of worship,” that gave representation to different faith groups. These policies were highly pragmatic in a country that was predominantly non-Muslim, but they were also a reflection of his eclectic spirituality, further revealed in his establishment of a cult based on the worship of light and sun (*din-i-ilahi*).

Music and art also interested Akbar. He induced the famed singer and musician, Tansen, to join his court, and began patronizing what became known as north Indian classical music. At Fatehpur Sikri, he established a school of Mughal painting, combining Persian

and Indian influences in a style that was to reach its peak during the reign of his son, Jahangir (1605–27).

Peak and decline

Jahangir’s son, Shah Jahan (1628–58), contributed more artistic treasures, such as the Taj Mahal at Agra and a majestic new capital at Delhi, which included the Red Fort and the Jama Masjid. These huge projects were also symbols of Mughal wealth, dependent on flourishing agriculture and trade. From his accession in 1658, the last “great” Mughal, Aurangzeb oversaw the expansion of the empire to its largest extent. Yet his reign also



Red Fort

Repeating scalloped arches of red sandstone in the Red Fort at Delhi. The Red Fort, or Lal Quil, was at the heart of Shah Jahan’s new city. From 1648 it functioned as his imperial palace and the Mughal administrative center.

AFTER

In the 18th century, Mughal sovereignty became limited to Delhi and its hinterland.

END OF MUGHAL RULE

The emperor retained some authority within India as a whole as the *shahanshah*, or “king of kings.” His court patronized religious and cultural developments.



BAHADUR SHAH II

EAST INDIA COMPANY

During the early 19th century, any remaining authority was eroded systematically by the expanding **East India Company 352 >>**. A final attempt to restore Mughal rule was connected to the Indian Mutiny of 1857. This led to the dissolution of the Mughal Empire and the establishment of British crown rule in India **352–53 >>**. **The last Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah II, died in exile in Burma in 1862.**

The paradise garden

The Taj Mahal garden is thought to represent paradise; the word “paradise” is from the ancient Persian for “walled garden.” Mughal formal gardens, *charbaghs* (four gardens), were based on those of the Persians, who saw great significance in the number four. The design was brought to India by Babur. The plan of the Taj Mahal garden (left) shows the use of units of four.

signified the beginning of the end. He was often away from his capital on military campaigns, and he depleted the treasury attempting to defeat the Marathas in the south who were trying to establish their own empire. Some scholars also believe his strict interpretation of Islam offended his Rajput collaborators and Hindu subjects.

The empire was further weakened by a rapid succession of rulers following Aurangzeb’s death in 1707. In 1739, Nadir Shah, the Safavids’ successor, sacked Delhi and seized the Mughal treasury. The empire was all but dead. In 1857, the British deposed Bahadur Shah II, the last Mughal emperor.